

Writing to describe

DESCRIPTIVE WRITING TELLS THE READER WHAT SOMETHING OR SOMEONE IS LIKE.

Many types of writing use description, from stories to advertisements. Descriptive writing uses particular words to paint a vivid image of something in the reader's head.

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◀ 84–85 Idioms, analogies, and figures of speech

◀ 182–183 Picking the right words

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Writing a narrative

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The senses

When writing to describe, it's important to appeal to the reader's senses. By describing what something looks, sounds, and feels like, a writer will allow the reader to imagine something in detail. Not all of the senses may be relevant, but try to think about as many as possible.



• One way to structure a description is to describe it **location by location**, as if moving around a scene with a video camera.

Barbara walked into the kitchen and was confronted by a rush of warm air and the smell of something sweet. On the counter was a triple-layer chocolate cake with fudge icing oozing down the sides. She eagerly cut a slice and stuffed it into her mouth. The chocolate sponge was rich and bitter with a slight nutty flavor. The sugar sprinkles crackled in her mouth and got stuck in her teeth. Suddenly, the doorbell rang. Barbara jumped, and her cake splattered across the floor.

Describe what something looks, feels, smells, tastes, and sounds like.

REAL WORLD

Too good to miss

Advertising executives use description to create tempting pictures in an audience's mind to persuade them to buy something. For example, they might describe hair as *smooth*, *glossy*, and *rich* to sell a new shampoo or hair dye. Alternatively, an advertisement for a beach resort could include descriptions such as *azure blue*, *gently lapping waves*, and *golden sands*.

